

THE IDES of March

| By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi |

The grainy footage of young men with backpacks holding Kalashnikov rifles brazenly, moving around openly in a public space and firing indiscriminately at the police and passersby, immediately recalled images of the commando-style operation in Mumbai on 26/11. But that is where the similarities ended. These latest images from 3/3—as the media dubbed the attack on March 3—were on Pakistani television screens first, captured from Liberty Chowk in the heart of Lahore, itself the heart of the Punjab province. The target of the dozen or so gunmen was clearly the visiting Sri Lankan cricket team, on its way at the time to the Gaddafi stadium for the third day of their second Test match against Pakistan. The mayhem lasted only about half an hour and at the end of it, while eight people lay dead—including six policemen—the attackers had slipped away and the Sri Lankans had miraculously survived without any fatalities.

As after the Mumbai carnage, however, the reputation of the provincial and federal government was in tatters and the image of the country devastated. Questions were immediately raised about the efficiency of the security provided to the visiting Sri Lankans, who had stepped in to fill a void created by the abrupt cancellation of an Indian cricket tour after 26/11 and defied misgivings about the security environment in Pakistan. The fact that so many gunmen managed to get so close to the route of the team bus

The attack on the Sri Lankan cricket team has bolstered the feeling within Pakistan that the Zardari Government does not have what it takes to control the country



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EXPERTS FEAR THE UNCHECKED VIOLENCE AND PO

and escape, points to a serious lapse on the part of the security establishment despite the heroic sacrifices of some policemen to protect their charges. In fact, it was nothing short of a miracle that the results were not much more horrific. The gunmen had first fired a rocket as well as lobbed two hand grenades at the bus, all of which missed their target. It was this simple

stroke of luck and the quick thinking of the bus driver—who sped away from the scene to the stadium while the police commandos engaged the attackers—that saved the Sri Lankan team from being held hostage or killed. Pakistan's future as a cricketing destination and indeed for tourism or investment has nevertheless been thrown into serious doubt.